# The Trip We Finally Took

## Bolivia- Chile- Argentina

## August 20,2025-September 18 , 2023

*The Nature Trip of a Life Time*

Today we embark on the most expensive, expansive, adventurous and hopefully exciting trip of our life time. Why? Because we think that at a combined age of 164 we still can and because world travel has been the passion of our lives. We travelled the world over on all seven continents including both poles (Arctic and Antarctica) and 82 different countries. We travelled for Nature, Culture and Adventure and this, the longest trip we ever made offers all three. But truth to be said. My wife of 62+ years is the architect, the visionary behind all our travels. Bolivia's Salt flats, Chile's Atacama desert and Northern Argentina Route 40 are a few remaining entries in her bucket list and I get to join!

8-20-25

We are now more than half way on our way to La Paz. We are flying Avianca Airlines to Bogotá, Colombia. Three hours into a five hour flight. The airline standards in North America and Europe are not to be seen. No TV entertainment, no reclining seats, no pillows, no blankets, no safety card or safety demonstration and one lousy Turkey sandwich. How spoiled are we.

We landed in La Paz at 3:30 in the morning and as soon as we stepped out of the airport the thin air of La Paz hit us with a sledge hammer. Especially mom. Suffice it to say that it was serious. For the first time ever I saw mom in a state of fear and anxiety. We made it to our boutique hotel and mom spent the day in bed. We were prepared for discomfort and that's what I felt but not for this. We did all the right things: hydrating, drinking coca tea, no coffee, light breakfast and chicken soup for dinner. The chicken soup was ordered by my new friend Rosa. Rosa is some 80+ years old. She works at the front desk. When she heard that mom was in trouble she left her desk took me by the hand and walked with me to a nearby restaurant. The young lady owner greeted both of us with a kiss on both cheeks. In Bolivia they eat soup for breakfast but Rosa asked her to cook one especially for us which she enthusiastically agreed and delivered it to our room. Rosa is such an interesting person. Speaks English fluently which she studied in Boston. She used to own a travel agency years back and travelled extensively. We befriended. Mom always says that there are always good people wherever we travel in the world who go out of their way to help. Rosa is one of those.

Early on I was ready to pack it in. Mom has always been the strongest most positive mentally and she cracked. I went out on the town to get mom special pills and a portable oxygen canister and we both slept for hours.

22-8-25

Mom woke up rejuvenated. Felt much better breathing and the fear and anxiety dissipated. We had a light breakfast and went out on the town for the first true test of walking the streets. La Paz for foreigners is not a pedestrian city.

As of the time of writing 11:45 we walked 2000 steps to a city plaza and now sitting on the bench and soaking the sun. All indications are that we're both on the mend, especially mom. Stay tuned.

We are back in our room at 4PM. We walked 6700 steps (tough but not too bad) We reached a consensus that people like us shouldn't be doing it but now that we did we'll try to make the most of it. Coming back on schedule will be a win. We got a feel for the city today at Plaza Murillo and went to the museum of ethnography and culture. Tomorrow we are starting our planned tour. We have a feeling that if we travel in a group they may shoot us for walking so slowly.

23-08-2025
A private guided tour of La Paz. First stop Moon Valley a unique clay rock formations that look like from another planet the moon. Wondrous

views that only picture can tell. It was our first test of walking up and down stairs and we passed. Not to miss when in La Paz. La Paz has two cities in one. The lower one and the highest Alto city. Transportation in the city by car looks worse than Toronto. The solution a unique network of cable cars as public transportation. We rode all 5 lines and soaked the views of the entire city. We then went into a store in the witches market where they sell all sorts of witchcraft for the rituals of the indigenous people. August is the month to make sacrifices and make wishes for health, money, love and more from the Pacha Mama (Mother Earth) which includes fetus lama babies and mummified young Lamas. We purchased Coca leaves for chewing when we get to Salt flats and some hand cream for sniffing all to fight high altitude symptoms.
For a first tour day we're doing better than a passing mark.

24-08-2025

This morning I heard from mom an unsolicited admission: “I must admit that I bit more than I can chew” She continued: “For the first time I believe that old age is a serious limiting factor” and we just about to start day 4 of 28.
This morning a two hours drive with a group to Tiwanaku archeological reserve of the most ancient civilization in South America. Now on the way back to La Paz after a somewhat underwhelming experience. The promotional pictures seem to offer more yet it was worth it. Walking was relatively easy. Flat terrain and mom almost made it all the way. At some point towards the end she called timeout. Mom knows her limits of her body but not always of her mind. This trip is a rude awakening that old age sucks but courage and curiosity shall never die.
La Paz may not be your first choice destination. Yes the city is photogenic while with the Alto city and its mountainous background, the monuments, the plazas with the beautiful garden designs, the street arts and many more big city amenities. But the city may have been called Chaos. They say that Toronto traffic is the worst. La Paz did not enter the competition or it would have won the title. No seatbelts in cars including driver, narrow winding streets most in disrepair, many poor neighbourhoods but always bustling. But if you came to see more of Bolivia there is not a better city to acclimatize to the high altitude and its weird effects there is no better place than La Paz.

25-08-2025

We left La Paz on a two days on a catamaran tour to lake Titicaca. Our first stop was at a small island population 150. It was a perfect example of rural indigenous Bolivia. A local woman demonstrated their main industry - cheese making. She started by milking a cow and proceeded to add to the fresh milk certain ingredients. We continued to tour the village and half an hour later we came back to taste what mom said was an excellent rich ricotta cheese. Back to the catamaran. A luxury 80 passengers capacity with only two guests-us. Spent the night on the catamaran in a private room. The day was not strenuous but the high altitude symptoms continue to haunt us

26-08-2025

Breakfast on the catamaran and off to Copa Cabana (not that one) and isle de Sol. Copa Cabana is a quaint town renowned for the church of the Madonna and for its fresh food market doubling as a sit and eat somewhat like but not as orderly as Lawrence market.

Bolivia is a poor country with a bad history of lost territory in war with all its neighbours : Brazil, Peru, Argentina, Chile and Colombia. Altogether some 60% since its independence. Bolivians especially rural indigenous people are poor but very religious and their rituals such as sacrifices to Pacha Mama is central in their identity. In Copa Cabana we discovered a new one. When you buy a new vehicle you drive to Copa Cabana where you decorate the car with all sort of colourful trinkets. Then the priest comes from the church sprays holy water on the car. The usually family and friends that come with the new owner pop up a bottle of Champaign and pours it on all sides of the car. We're told the many people from all over the world are driving from afar to Copa Cabana to christen their car by the priest of the Madonna.

Off to Isle de Sol the most popular tourist destination. Both are on the shores of Titicaca. We cannot say much about Sun Island. In order to experience it you have to climb 209 uneven rocky stairs. One look and mom was out. There is no way in hell that she could make it. Me the machismo decided to try and after 37 steps realized that this is not for us people and came down. Grace our excellent guide explained to us what we will see once we get to the top so we feel like we saw it. Grace is by far the best tour guide we encountered in all our travels. Extremely knowledgeable, helpful and caring. Back to La Paz for a sleep over. Tomorrow begins the most challenging part of our tour: The salt flats of UYIUNI in altitudes of 3600-5000. We may be better acclimatized but

our performance till now has been poor.

27-08-2025
Good bye La Paz. We are on our true challenge of this crazy ordeal on our way to Uyuni.
La Paz summary:
Planning : perfect (pacing)
Execution (Hosts):exceeded expectations (10)
Execution (Travellers) Poor to Unqualified
27-08-2025
We hope it's not an omen. The first spot on our 3 days tour of Uyuni was the Locomotive cemetery where old trains go to die. Just kidding a real attraction. Of course the salt factory and museum. Uyuni can supply the world with salt until the end of day. We finally arrived at the salt flats. What to say? It's like when mom and Sharon answered when they came back from the arctic: AWESOME. The vastness. Miles and miles of white (salt) as far as the eye can see. We are again thankfully on a private tour. Our driver Spanish speaking Emerson preferred to be called Eddy guide will spend all 3 days with us. Why Spanish guide when we could have spent extra $300 US for an English speaking? Uyuni is all about seeing there are very little explanations. Take a deep breath and experience the view. Eddy served us lunch and a tasty one too. On the salt flats where

we were the only people as far as the eye can see. I will never forget the awesomeness of this lunch. Next we went to a magical island with beautiful rock formations and a field of cactuses forming incredible pictures. By then we said to each other this the seventh day was already the best so far. First we are reasonably acclimatized, walking on salt flats is much easier and the sights are breathtaking. Good choice Mama. Now we are in a 5 star hotel right next to the flat. You have to see it to understand why it is so unique.

The best part of the day and hopefully for the rest of the trip: Mom is doing much better as long as we are flat. I fell in love again with this woman. While for her courage, curiosity, common sense, resilience and positive attitude under conditions that I would have folded. Alis the Lioness.

28-08-2025
Today was another successful day. We toured the Chicho desert beginning with the rock formation forest. What nature can randomly create is mind boggling. You can clearly see faces of animals, faces of humans and other earthly things carved out of the natural erosion. We proceed to a large lagoon nestled between desert mountains and serves

as a sanctuary for hundreds of flamingos. Little walking only to take pictures and back to the car. Mom made it through the day still with some difficulties. Not so much the breathing more weakness in the legs. But she made it as always. We just checked in to our biggest test of this trip. Our last night in Bolivia at a hotel perched 5000 M above see level. If we wake up in the morning we passed.

29-08-2025

Breaking news: we woke up in the morning despite some difficult breathing we have not encountered before, especially me. But we're alive and that's a win. At 7am we began our third tour of the day and it was just as awesome as the last two days. I even dipped in the hot springs. The desert in south of the Salar in Bolivia is fascinating. Driving through it you can't but admire nature for creating such wonders. The multicoloured mountains, the lagoons nesting below. We are now in Chile and tomorrow we start our Chilean itinerary. The physical toll on both of us and especially mom is creeping up on us. But we're alive soldiering on. Adios Bolivia

30-08-2025
Dan Pedro de Atacama is sandy windy and dusty. Not good for both our lungs but likely nothing compared to tomorrow's tour to Moon Valley. We shall survive. Why don't they produce a series Survivor for seniors. Our Astronomical tour tonight has been cancelled due to high winds that cause a lot of dust. We'll make up for it in La Serena home of the largest telescope in the world( mom's latest interest)
31-08-2025
Today we are beginning our tour of the Atacama desert in Chile.

As I write we are back to the hotel from the morning tour. So far we thought that nothing would impress us more than the salt flats in Bolivia. We were wrong the Atacama desert must be included in the list of world wonders if it's not already. The scenery is like from another planet. The mountains, rock formations, changing colours from brown to red to green. Most importantly mom made it all the way as some walking and minor climbing was involved. The pictures are award winning. Not because we are good photographers the objects of our pictures speak for themselves. Later this afternoon-lagoons.

01-09-2025

Definition of crazy: 4:30AM driving up to 4100M with the temperature -16C to watch the Tatio geysers park in the Atacama desert. It's a unique phenomena as we see in the pictures. But still crazy. Never in my life did I touch so many asses then on this trip.correction I touched one ass many time. You see mom has a problem lifting her body weight, so we have this ritual when we board the van she starts and then say NOW! Signalling me to lift her behind which I do many time with pleasure. What we did today will go down in the annals of the Zohar family history as a proof of mind over matter. We started the day at 4:30 and stopped at 4500M and -16C. In the afternoon we went to Valle de Luna where the temperature was 34C with 0 humidity. We climbed a sandy rocky 45

degrees pathway. And… mom made it (with great difficulty to be honest) because she is mom. I am in awe of her will of power and resilience.

02-09-2025
Today is our final day in the Atacama desert and the longest one. Ten hours and 400 km by car and what appears to be almost the same distance walking. The Atacama expedition is spectacular and awe inspiring. But for us it is like a Marines boot camp. We almost lost a soldier when mom fell backwards thankfully on her back and not her head. This is the second fall on this trip but no damage done. Before I forget the guides without exception are first rate. Knowledgeable, proud of their land, caring and with a good sense of humour. Both mom and I took a pass on a 3 km hike at 4000+ elevation which apparently is too challenging for both of us while the wind and the elevation. You have to know your limits. The guide said that mom is a certain NO and me a difficult one. We have nothing to prove so we'll get the photos of the red rocks at the end of the hike and pretend we've been there.
Chile is one of the richest countries when it comes to minerals like lithium and other rare minerals. Of course in the race for AI supremacy between the US and China large mining companies from both countries are buying rights and mining the minerals for profit. As the two countries compete it opens up the door for corruption. Including bribes to decision maker like governors of the area for mining rights. The consequences are devastating for the environment. They do not follow responsible ecosystem protection guidelines and why would they it's not their country. When challenged they respond by saying: we employ so many thousands of Chilean in our mining operations you should be thankful. Don't bother us with the environment. In the meantime the ecosystem (God's creation) is being disturbed. Certain species are forced out of their areas of habitation and may become extinct. Humans are allowed to swim in lagoons and scare away the native population of birds

and flamingos which upset the ecosystem balance. A real dilemma: jobs and profits v environmental protection.

03-09-2025

Last night we completed the most mentally and physically challenging segment of our adventure. We are now headed towards some urbanization on our way to Santiago de Chile. Today was a designated travel day. Drive to Calama airport flight to Santiago. For dinner we were taken as only tourists can. We went down for a walk on the Main Street and chose a restaurant at random. Mom ordered a stake and I ordered chicken and beef skewers. You would not believe what was served. Not one stake but 3 decent size stakes. Good but way too much. For me four skewers with six healthy chunks of beef and chicken. Good but I could hardly finished one. The server we thought should have alerted us that these are huge portions but of course why should she. Tomorrow we'll explore the old city and celebrate my birthday at a more tourist friendly restaurant.

04-09-2025

My birthday. I was flooded by happy birthday wishes from the people I love and that includes the "Refugees" which was an extra honor. Today is

our first free day in Santiago de Chile. We originally planned it to be a couple of rest days once we made in past the first season of Survivor. Until mom asked if by any chance there is a memorial or a museum dedicated to the darkest day in Chilean history namely the junta coup of Pinochet and the ensuing atrocities that followed which Chileans remember as their holocaust. From 1973 to 1990 Pinochet and his junta ruled Chile and conducted a systematic reign of terror and brutality against " the enemy of the people" (familiar?) the coup quickly became a full fledged fascism regime with unmatched brutality. Sure enough Chileans remember and we spent almost four hours in the museum of Memory and Human Rights on (coincidentally?) the outskirts of the city with few if any tourists but many school children in organized mandatory visit to the museum as part of their educational curriculum. It is a fascinating yet outraging account of this period and reminded us of Yad Va Shem in Jerusalem. Mom has such a sense for what is right and important. I would not have thought about it even though it is extremely pertinent to my upcoming fall lecture series: The slippery slope from Populism to Fascism. In fact I collected some relevant material for my lecture series. We spent the rest of the afternoon in the heart of the old city and walked the streets outside Plaza de Arms.

05-09-2025

Santiago is a big city but not much to write home about. We did the must do when in Santiago: This morning we spent a few hours at the famous San Cristobal. A huge park on the hill overlooking the city. We climb up by cable car to the top of the hill. The views of the city on the background of the snow peaked mountains is worth the trip. From there we were tempted to check off another must see: The Palace Square. There happened to be an exhibition of indigenous women from different regions of Chile selling their original art, jewelry and other original artifacts.

06-09-2025

This morning we're headed to La Serena for 24 hours before departing tomorrow to Boenos Aires. Why? Because mom is curious about the heavens so we have booked an evening tour of the world's largest telescope to star gaze and explore the galaxies. The tour started with a 90 minutes drive to the observatory in the town of Vicuña. These telescopes are used for tourism as an educational experience and not by Astronomers taking advantage of the clearest skies unique to this area. We learned plenty, saw some fascinating views of stars in the galaxy and

especially the surface of the moon. This is the price for curiosity and it’s worthwhile.

07-09-2025

Today is travel day. La Serena to Santiago in the morning and Santiago to Buenos Aires in the afternoon. Night at an airport hotel next day Salta. Nothing more to report. We did not have a single snafu thru out our trip so far. Until arrived in Bones Aires. We were planning to go from La Serena to Santiago to Buenos Aires all in one day. In hindsight we should have done so. Instead we booked a “hotel”near the airport to rest the night and continue to Salta the next day. This so called inn was an absolute dive with all the trimmings. A an old witch looking owner with an old lame dog offered us the one room in the inn more like a one bedroom Airbnb in the back yard of her own home. Clean, warm for sure but spooky. We made it through the night alright and are heading to Salta today.

08-09-2025

We spent the best part of the day at the airport waiting to board the 2:40 flight to Salta. We all make mistakes.

What an irony. Mom has every ailment in the book and it is simply amazing how she soldiered through under unprecedented physical challenges. Me, I just come down with a bad cold with all the trimming, sneaking, runny nose, coughing one which I have not experienced for many years at home. Who is the macho now?

Now in Salta we are at the heart of the old city and fell in love with the Plaza 6 July. Not only the garden, the sculptures and the surrounding colonial buildings, but it is a meeting place for the community. On a Monday evening it’s full of families and friends out for a stroll. Sometimes we wish there were places like this in Toronto.

10-09-2025

Our first North Argentina tour started with a long dissertation of the entire route to which I whispered: Too much information. Who could possibly remember the names of all the towns we are going to drive through? Then an hour into the tour: flat tire. What a start? Our tour continues to San Salvador de Jujuy where the spare tire is being replaced by the repaired original one. Another 45 minutes. It must get better from here. It did. Especially when we arrived at Purmamarca home of the hills of seven colours. Plenty of pictures, and HumaHaca where we had lunch with live music. If Erin can eat horse and donkey in France Sabba can eat Llama in Argentina. Tender and delicious.

On our way back the Mercedes Benz mini bus broke down again and we were stranded for an hour and a half waiting for a replacement car. Oh yes upon our arrival to the hotel Mom registered the third official fall of this trip. Thank goodness that it did no great harm other than splashing two cafe lattes all over the reception when she missed an elevated step. Brushed it off as if nothing happened. That’s mom for you.

10-09-2025

What a different a day makes. We are driving through the Andes. The views are the most spectacular than whatever we have seen so far. On top of that our guide Paulino is totally fluent in English, is engaging, and we

learned more from him about life, culture and climate of Argentina and especially the Salta region. We have been to Moon Valleys in Bolivia and Chile but today we drove through Moon Valley in Northern Argentina and we are at awe of what we saw driving through it. The other two are pretenders. If we thought nothing better than the Andes landscapes was possible - this Moon valley produced scenes from a different world that only pictures can explain. By far the best touring day of our entire trip so far. As if we planned it, every new day seems to feel like the best -So far. Staying the night in Calafate in a cozy colonial mansion turned hotel- So quaint.

11-09-2025

Sometimes we wonder how God created this magnificent world in 7 day and it took us almost a month to explore a minuscule but awe inspiring tiny slice of it. We travel for culture, nature and adventures. This trip was full of nature, some culture and the adventure part was that we 82 years old manage to do it all in the face of serious physical limitations. Today's crossing the Andes may remain as the most spectacular drive we took anywhere in the world. We are likely to take more pictures today than in

any other. We enter the town of Chachi now driving on Ruta Quarenta, a realization of mom's dream. We are driving back to Salta in yet another mountain range. We stopped 10 or more times for taking photos of the most fascinating rock formations that nature created in the image of real things such as animals and people totally randomly. There is no question at this point that this tour was the best of all the best places we've tours. Just watch the pictures.

12-09-2025

From the majestic mountains and canyons, today we are headed to the jungle. We are the second couple to take this tour this year and the first Canadians to do so. Now we understand why. We drove for than 5 hrs, on torturous gravel, rocks "roads" where we saw some birds, wild pigs and a lot of mosquitos and also tics for which we used a special repellent spray. The jungle? We saw many better than this in our travels. Nothing compared to the excitement of the last two days. We are reaching the point of diminishing returns. The good news: we have walked today, day 23, more than in any other day. 14,,000 steps (in a row!) and the lioness keeps hunting!

13-09-2025

Today is our last touring day before departing to Buenos Aires for two days of acclimating to big city life after our almost all nature tour. We were lucky in planning as Monday is the huge Catholic party in Salta where tens or more thousands of people from all over the Salta province and also from Chile and Peru gather. It is a unique event only in Salta. Pilgrims from rural communities some times hundreds of kilometres away embark on a walk to the Salta cathedral where the ceremonies are held. It is a unique, unbelievable demonstration of faith when all families from babies to children to adults to the elderly and even the handicaps are marching for WEEKS by foot. There is an incredible logistic challenge to feed and house the pilgrims for whom food and shelter is provided for free. The festival is called Feriado. We are once again on a private tour with our favourite guide Mauricio. The rock formations are different but as spectacular. As we climbed up to 4200M (again) we seem to handle it much better in fact like veterans of high altitude. Another day of adventure in the books.

14-09-2025

We made it! This trip has been a dream of mom and became an inspirational experience for both of us. The sights we have seen will be etched in our memory as the most spectacular we have ever seen in all our travels. The planning of the trip by mom was a master class. Every day we saw more and many times even better than the previous day. We learned a lot about the countries and places we visited. But above all we learned a lot about ourselves and our ability even this late in our lives to explore, endure and over come both physical and mental challenges we never experienced before in all our travels. Finally our team is solid. We worked well together, helped each other in times of need and shared a common experience we'll never forget.

Our trip is not yet over. Today we fly to Buenos Aires and relax for a couple of days in our familiar habitat - the big city before coming home. It's not over yet but our trip was just as we described in the opening of

this travel log: The most expensive, expansive and most exciting trip of our life time (so far, as mom's list is not yet completed) Today is a travel day nothing to report.

15-09-2025

Today we are regular tourists in the big and beautiful city of Buenos Aires. First we went to the colourful famous La Boca home of Boca Juniors. You have to see the pictures to appreciate its uniqueness. We have been here before and coming back to take more of the colourful building and murals and of course worship the Argentinian heroes Maradona and Messi. Next the colonial buildings around Plaza de Mayo in San Telmo and a long walk to the Saint Lawrence (San Telmo) market for lunch a beer. After almost a month we are still walking 10K. Mom on a lame knee and I with a lingering cold and a never ending cough.

16-09-2025

Today our tourist visa expires and we'll be heading home tomorrow morning. Today we had some expectations to find Palermo SoHo and Palermo Hollywood exciting places. It was a bit of a bust or may be we came too ear in the morning where they say late at night and weekends the place is hoping. But instead we are soaking the warm sun in one of the many plazas like people our age should do. We have become a bit spoiled when it comes to big city tourism plus we've been to Buenos

Aires twice before. Old colonial building or monuments? Been there done this. Fine dining? Done that. In hindsight the two days in Buenos Aires may have been redundant may be except for the rest.

Time to some up:
This has been the most exciting yet most demanding, the longest the most expensive trip we ever done. Was it worth it? Hell yes! What we saw, what we learned about places we saw as well as about our own resilience was all worth it and will be forever remembered. But we stretched ourselves to the limit so next trip better be easier.
Mom offered her own:
This has been a nature trip that was the most impactful and exciting but also the most rigorous and demanding. But it was more than worth it.
Next stop: Toronto!






VALLE DE LA LUNA





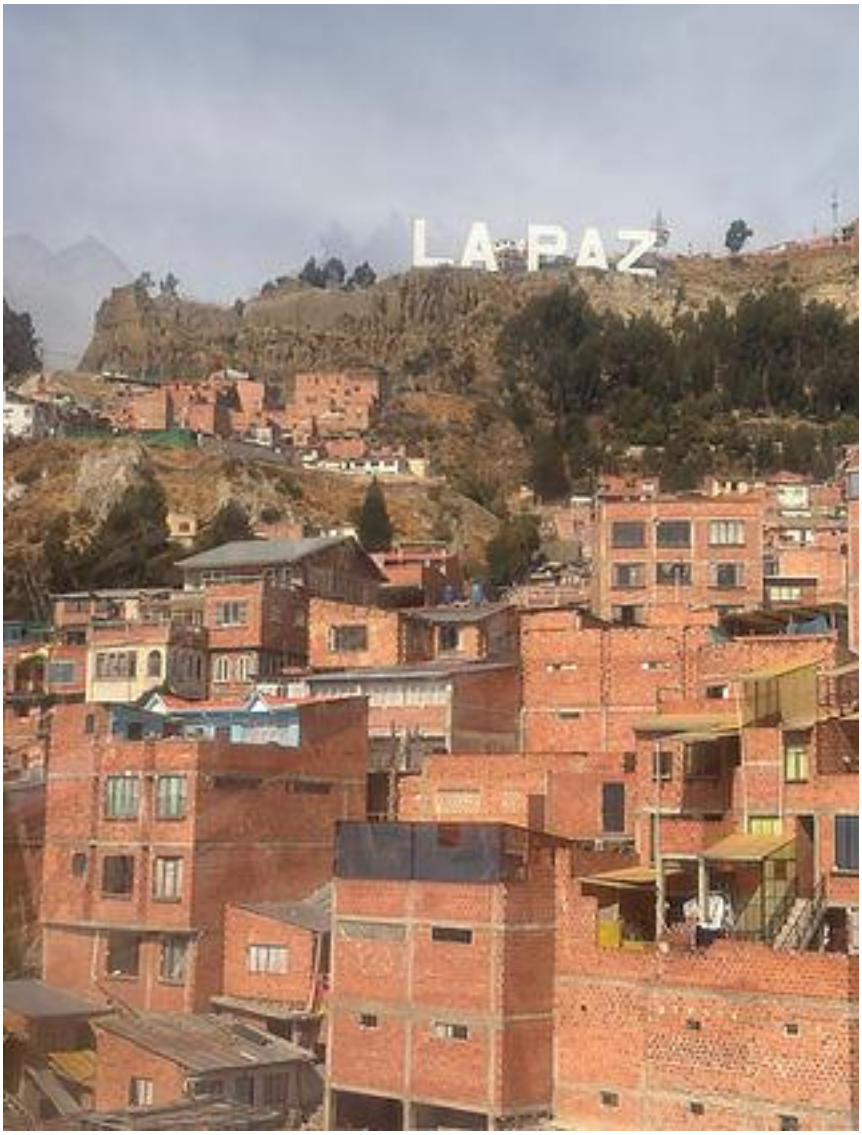






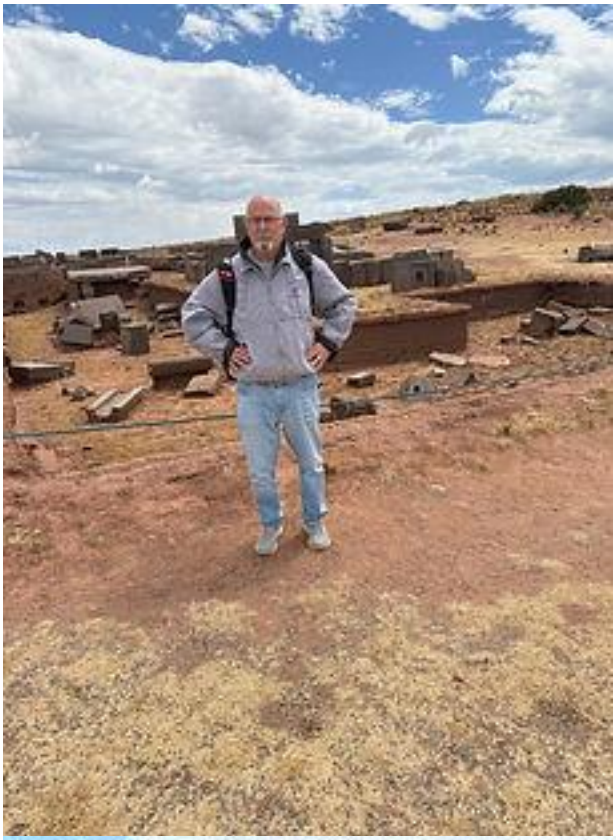



SERGEOMIN


LA PAZ






































DAKAR
BOLIVIA

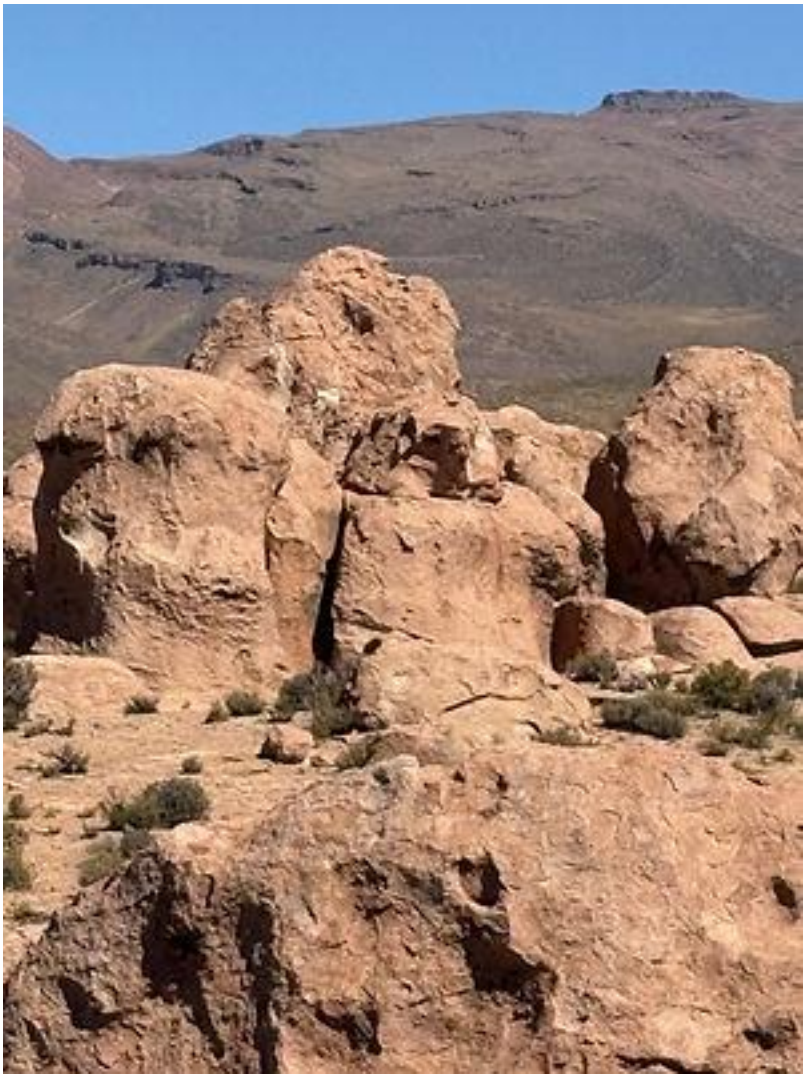











































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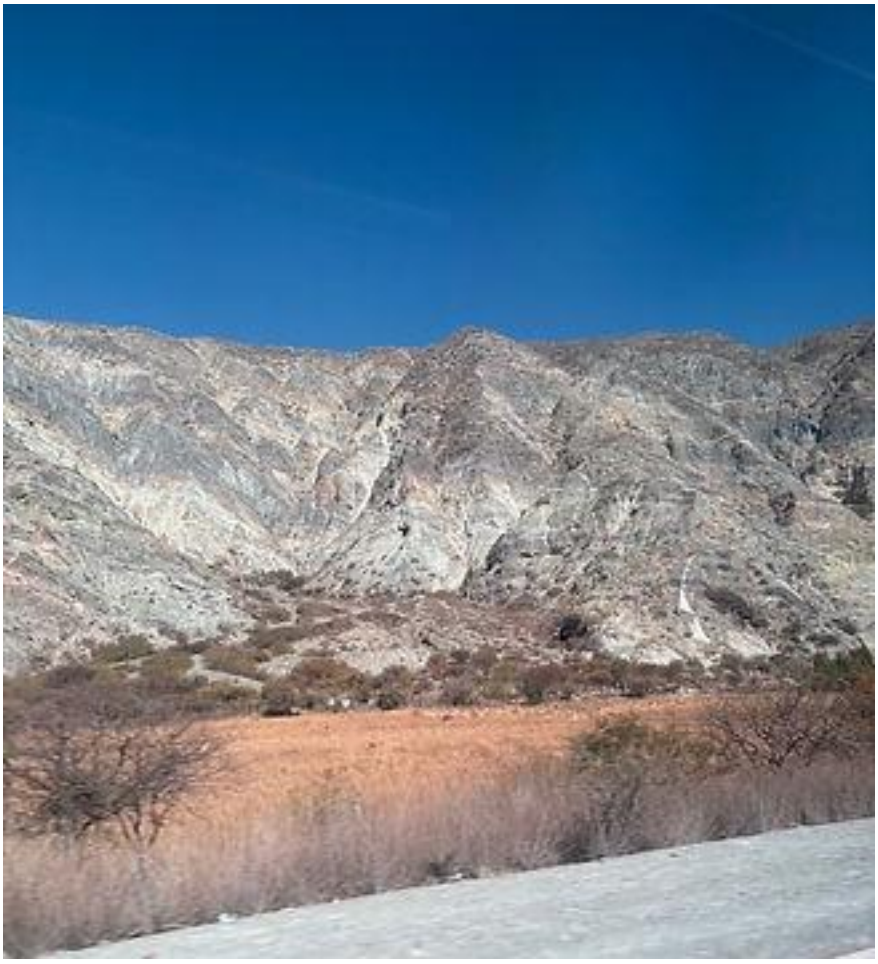


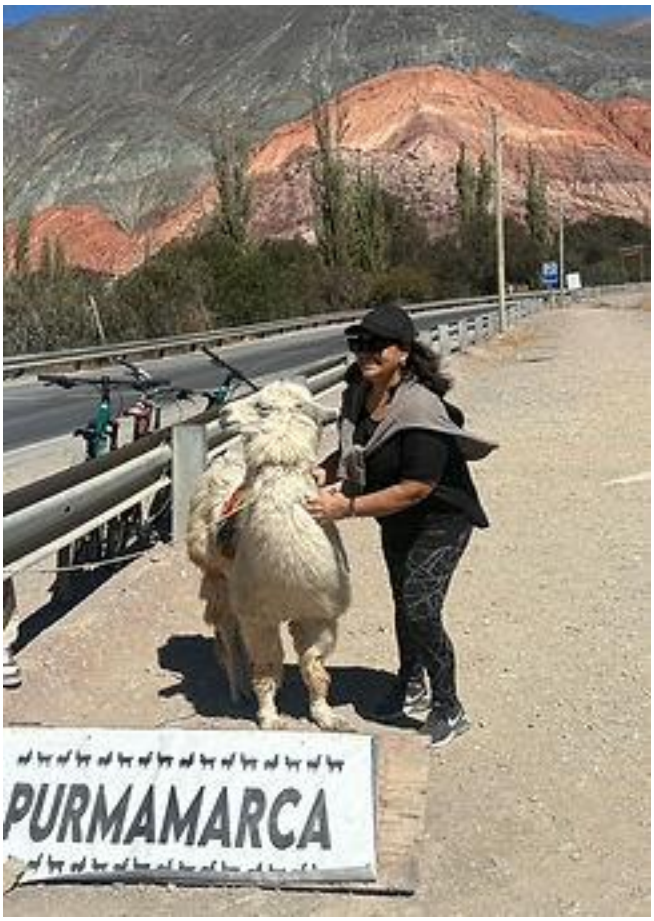


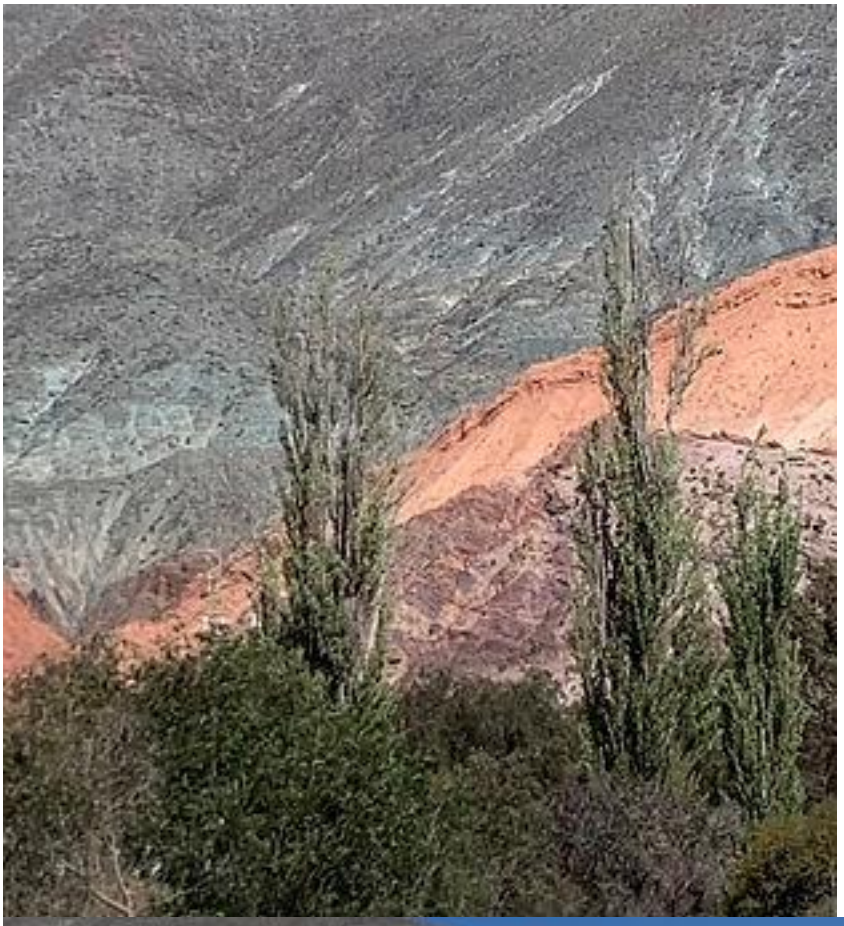









PURMAMARCA




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BIENVENIDOS
A
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LA BOCA
RESISTE Y PROPONE
ACCION SUDAKA MURAL


CHOPERIA




VAUQUITA




PALERMO

